

**GROUNDING: Disused  
trainer aircraft at the  
Patiala Flying Club**



ISHAN TANKHA

The boom in the aviation sector has triggered a huge demand for pilots but India's obsolete flying clubs lack infrastructure and instructors to meet the demand

down. At the Patiala flying club, Punjab's only functional training institute, only 30 trainees fly regularly while 70 wannabes are in queue because there is only one chief flying instructor. "There is a huge demand for flying lessons which we can't meet," says Captain Abhay Chandra, chief manager of the state flying clubs. The country's first, the Bombay Flying Club at the Juhu aerodrome—founded by the father of Indian aviation, J.R.D. Tata in 1929—now offers only ground training lessons. It functions as a maintenance hub for trainer aircraft from across the country because Mumbai's dense air traffic—over 600 flights every day—ensures all the club's flight training is conducted out of Baroda.

In the pre-boom years, between 1990 and 2003, India produced a leisurely 100 pilots every year. This year alone, 368 pilot licences and 114 Airline Transport Pilot Licences (ATPL) have been issued. Even this boom has not kept pace with increasing demand. At least 5,000 new pilots will be needed to fly the estimated 400 aircraft ordered by various airlines (each aircraft needs between 12 and 16 pilots)

over the next five years. The demand-supply gap is only set to widen over the years. Boeing subsidiary Alteon Training estimates the requirement will increase to more than 15,000 pilots a year in the next 20 years.

Yet, on the ground, the pilot training sub-sector is hamstrung by the government which has unshackled civil aviation. In September 2005, the Ministry of Civil Aviation (MOCA) sanctioned Rs 12 crore to buy 12 Cessna 172 trainer aircraft to be given to the Aero Club of India, the apex body of all flying clubs. Deliveries of the aircraft will be completed only by January next year. A case of too little, too late. "Each aircraft can do only about 1,200 hours of flying every year, enough to train just six pilots. This is a joke when you need thousands of pilots," says a flying club official.

An exodus of qualified instructors (with 2,500 hours of flying experience), and engineers to private airlines and flying academies has grounded several flying clubs. The Government pays them Rs 40,000 a month but, private players offer a monthly package of Rs 3 lakh. Indore-based Yash Air, India's

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